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Homelessness in higher education + Making sure primary voters count + SNAP benefits battle

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Good morning, California! Thanks for starting your day with the Capitol Alert team.

It's the moment many Democrats have been waiting for...a formal inquiry into impeachment proceedings.

To read up on House Speaker Nancy Pelosi's announcement that her chamber would officially look in to President Donald Trump's alleged digging up dirt on Joe Biden via a phone call with Ukraine's president, click here.

Meanwhile, in California...

MEASURING SUCCESS

How can students at California public universities and community colleges be successful when they can't make rent, pay for groceries or afford tuition?

That's a question posed by the California Homeless Youth Project in a September 2019 report that analyzed resources on college campuses for students who are on the edge of or already experiencing homelessness and food shortages.

The study reviewed 44 percent of California's 114 community colleges, and all of the California State and University of California schools.

What the project discovered:

One in five community college students, one in 10 at CSU and one in 20 at UC schools reported at least one experience with homelessness while in school. Those numbers increase when considering food insecurity. Students at community colleges are more likely to face housing and resource insecurities, yet don't have access to as much on-campus help that's offered at the four-year universities. Most of the schools provide support services like free grocery distribution, housing insecurity advisers, emergency grants, short-term loan assistance and emergency or year-round housing options. But the students who find themselves having to utilize the resources are more prone to "stress, depression, severe anxiety, disordered eating and suicidal ideation."

"Without a 'fixed, regular, and adequate nighttime residence,' these students must double up with other people, live in their cars, stay in emergency shelters, or sleep outside," the report's author Nancy LePage wrote, continuing that students who face these obstacles "are more likely to report having lower grades and lower overall grade point averages compared to students whose basic needs are met."

The project recommends additional investment in year-round and affordable student housing, foster youth programs and intervention methods for those on the brink of or already facing homelessness.

Noteworthy — A measure to allow community college students to sleep in their campus parking lots failed earlier this month, after Assemblyman Marc Berman, D-Palo Alto, pulled his Assembly Bill 302 following Senate Appropriations amendments he said would stigmatize and weaken the emergency shelter effort.

Gov. Gavin Newsom, however, authorized $42.6 million to finance a second year of of free community college tuition that would help out an estimated 33,000 students, his office noted in late August.

“This is real help for students trying to improve their lives and build their future,” Newsom said. “No one can argue with the fact that the full cost of attending institutions of higher learning is still far too high – both in California and across the country. But by offering two years of community college tuition-free, California is taking a meaningful step toward chipping away at the cost of higher learning for students and their families.”

PRIMARY VOTING

On top of their effort to move the state’s primary election to March, California Democrats now want people to see more voting reminder notifications and to have an option to register the day of an election.

Remind me — former Gov. Jerry Brown moved the primary up in March, making California a more influential voice during the road to the White House.

But, as The Bee’s Sophia Bollag reports, California has a growing percentage, slightly more than a quarter, of voters who report a “no party preference.” That means these state voters, and the two-thirds of them who vote by mail, could be out of luck if they try to cast a ballot in the primary.

That’s because “under the state’s rules no-party-preference voters must either register with a presidential party or request a party ballot to vote in a presidential primary,” Bollag notes. “If they’re a vote-by-mail voter, they must make the request by mail a week in advance.”

The California Democratic Party is increasing efforts to turn those NPPs into Democrats. In the meantime, Assemblywoman Lorena Gonzalez, D-San Diego, wrote a bill up for consideration by Newsom that would notify voters of their registration much earlier and require officials to send instructions on how to request a presidential primary ballot.

Gonzalez has said that her proposal, Assembly Bill 681, would reduce confusion and raise voting awareness.

“In the last election, we saw a lot of confusion when people didn’t understand why there were no presidential candidates on their ballot,” Gonzalez said when the Assembly passed the bill in May. “Which led to people thinking there was some sort of conspiracy.”

Newsom has until Oct. 13 to sign or veto the measure, as well as Senate Bill 72, which would require all voting locations to allow same-day voter registration.

OH SNAP!

California Attorney General Xavier Becerra joined 23 other attorneys general in denouncing the federal government’s proposal to limit access to the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program.

The U.S. Department of Agriculture Food and Nutrition Services proposed a rule in July to close a “loophole” that it argues allows families to obtain “categorical eligibility” for SNAP benefits if they already qualify for other programs, such as the Temporary Assistance for Needy Families.

“This proposed rule slams the door on families in need of assistance and jeopardizes food security for hundreds of thousands of hard-working, low-income Californians,” Becerra said.

In their letter, the attorneys general said SNAP serves as an “anti-hunger” initiative that provides “crucial non-cash nutritional support for millions of low-income individuals and families.”

There are more than 36 million people who utilize the program, according to the letter. The federal government estimates that 3.1 million SNAP participants would lose eligibility.

“Extending categorical eligibility to participants who have not been screened for eligibility compromises program

integrity and reduces public confidence that benefits are being provided to eligible households," the proposed rule states.

HAPPY BIRTHDAY!

September 25 — Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino

September 25 — Sen. Tom Umberg, D-Santa Ana

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